

SUPPLY-CHAIN DISRUPTION BRIEF

Container traffic through the Strait of Hormuz has run near zero since March

Five months on, box-ship transits sit at roughly one-tenth of their pre-crisis rate – and the cargo they would have carried has rerouted, not resumed.

By Michael Schertz Tooling bottleneck-logistics (open-source) Generated 30 Aug 2026

Source IMF PortWatch Method see § Method & provenance

HORMUZ CONTAINER TRANSITS 9% of normal 1.0 / day in July vs 11.1 / day pre-crisis	CONTAINER CARGO CAPACITY 6% of normal Capacity fell as hard as vessel count
JEBEL ALI CONTAINER CALLS 18% of normal The Gulf's main box hub, effectively offline	DURATION 6 months Onset March 2026, no recovery trend

§ 1 The finding

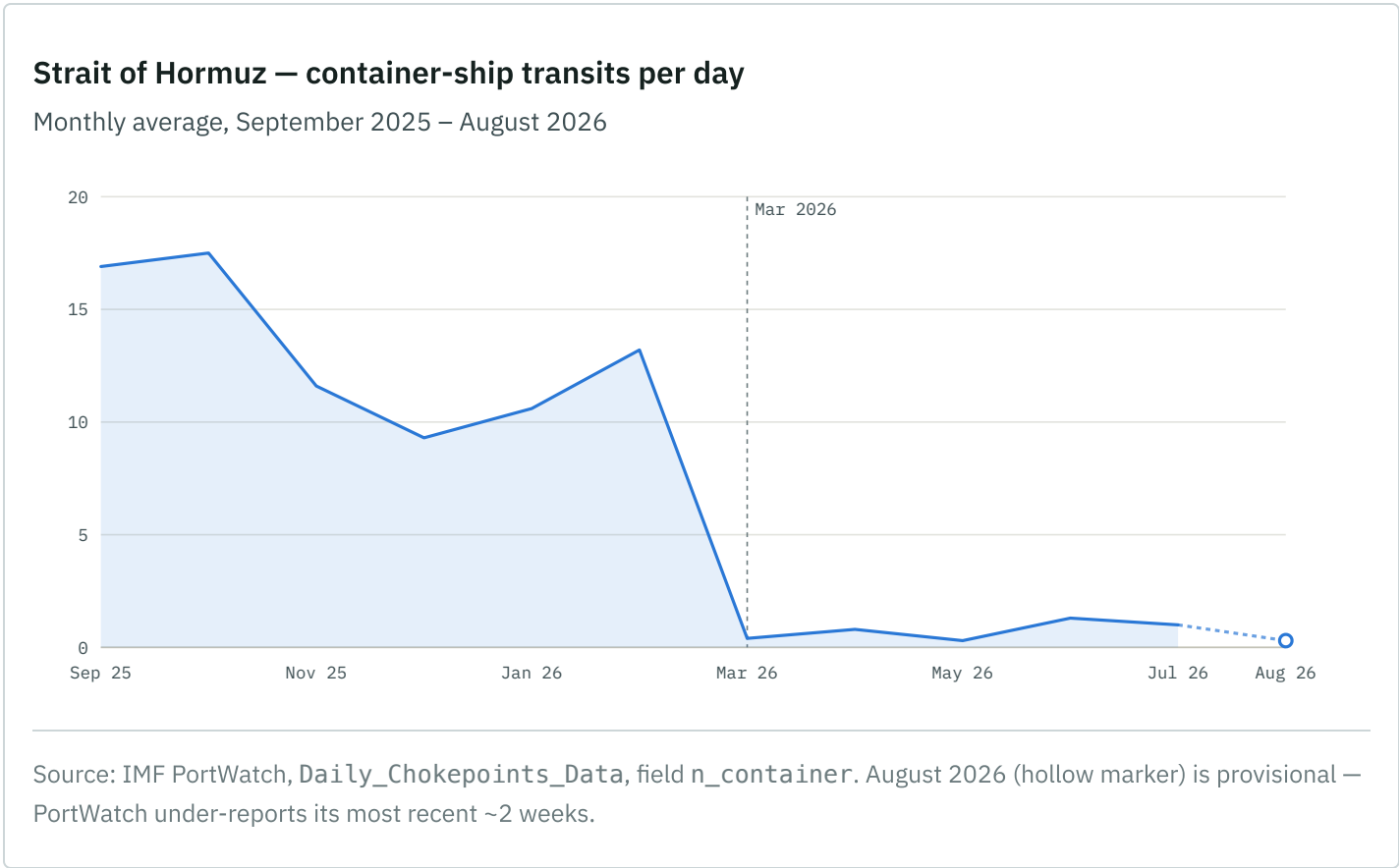
The question was whether the disruption is still ongoing or has returned to normal. For container shipping, the answer is unambiguous: ongoing, and total.

IMF PortWatch estimates daily vessel movements at 28 maritime chokepoints from satellite AIS. Through the Strait of Hormuz — the entrance to the Persian Gulf, coded *chokepoint 6* — container-ship transits averaged **11 per day** in the four months before March 2026. Since March they have averaged **under one per day**, and the most recent clean month (July) sits at **1.0 per day**. August is tracking lower still, though PortWatch revises its most recent weeks upward as more satellite data arrives, so that figure is provisional.

This is not a slowdown. It is the near-complete removal of container shipping from the route, sustained for half a year with no upward trend.

§ 2 The collapse

Container transits held between 9 and 18 per day through February 2026, then fell off a cliff in March and have not come back. The brief mid-year uptick — 1.3 per day in June — did not hold.



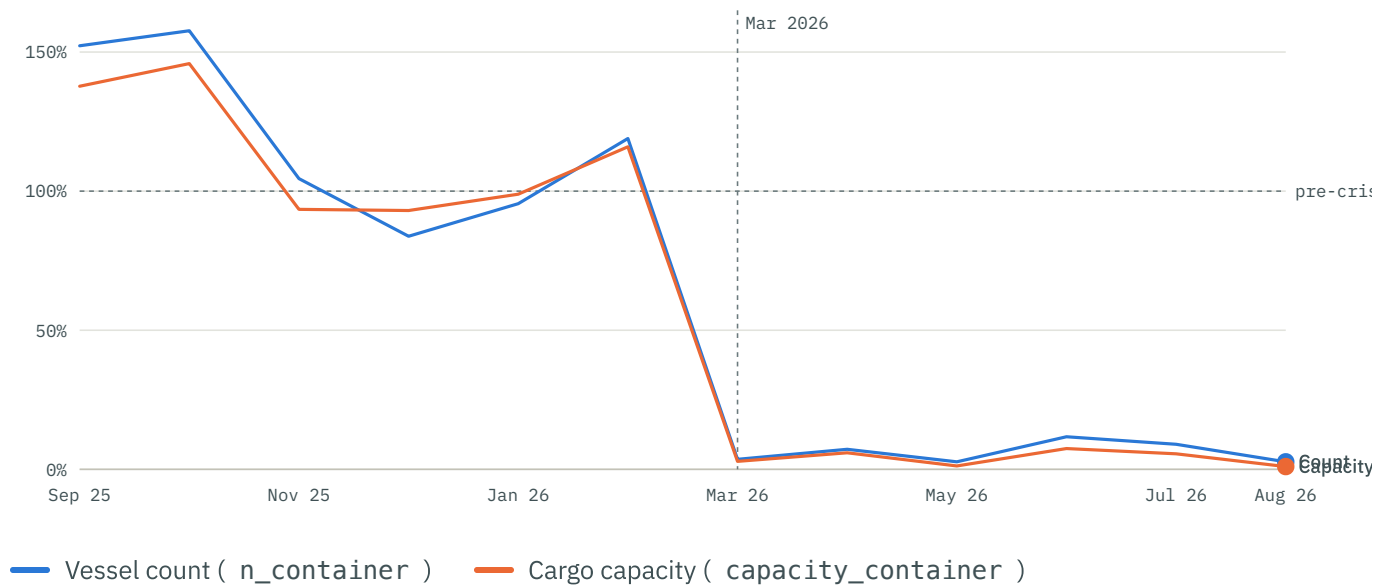
§ 3 Blocked, not merely thinned

A drop in *vessel count* alone is ambiguous — it could mean fewer, larger ships moving the same cargo. It doesn't. PortWatch also estimates the aggregate cargo *capacity* of transiting vessels, and capacity fell in near-perfect lockstep with the count — in fact slightly harder. The few box ships still using the strait are **smaller** than the pre-crisis norm, not larger.

The collapse is also **uniform across every cargo class** — tankers, containers, dry bulk, ro-ro all fell to between zero and roughly 15 % of a year earlier. That is the signature of a route-wide closure, not a commodity-specific restriction, which would gut tankers while sparing containers.

Vessel count and cargo capacity fell together

Container traffic through Hormuz, indexed to the Nov 2025 – Feb 2026 average (= 100)



Source: IMF PortWatch, Daily_Chokepoints_Data. Both series divided by their own pre-crisis mean, so 100 = the pre-crisis normal for each.

WHY THIS MATTERS

If the count had dropped while capacity held, a count-based alarm would be a false positive — cargo still flowing on bigger ships. Here both lines fall to the floor together: real throughput is gone.

§ 4 Jebel Ali goes dark

Jebel Ali (Dubai) is the Gulf's dominant container port and one of the ten busiest in the world — the region's transshipment anchor. It sits *inside* the strait. Its container operation tracked the chokepoint almost exactly: ~13 container port calls per day through February, then **0.6 in March**, recovering only to ~2 per day by mid-summer. Estimated container trade volume — imports and exports — is running at **15–20% of pre-crisis levels**.

Jebel Ali — container port calls per day

Monthly average, September 2025 – August 2026



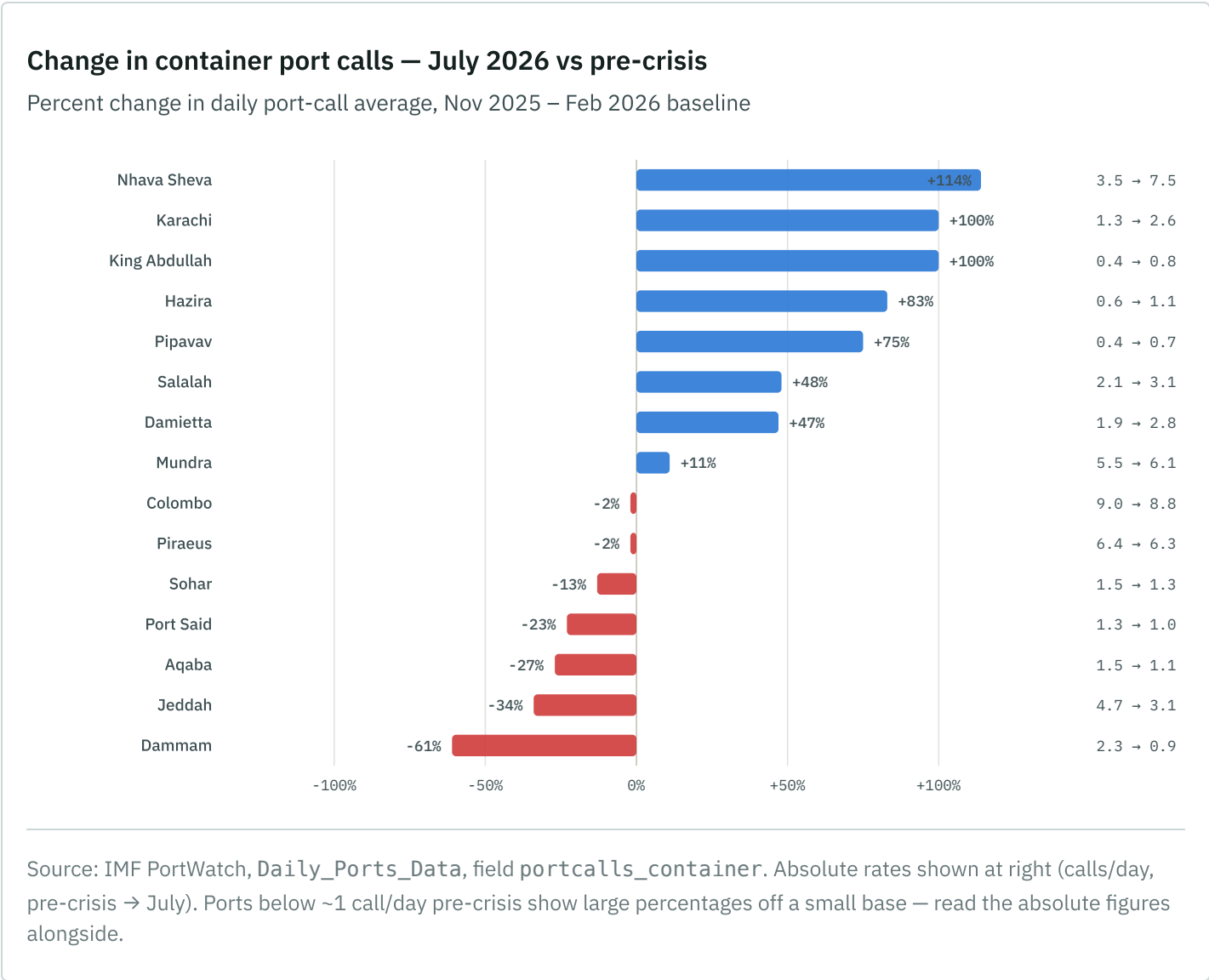
Source: IMF PortWatch, Daily_Ports_Data, field portcalls_container, port ID port744.

§ 5 Where the containers went

Cargo that would have moved through the Gulf has rerouted — and not to the usual transshipment hubs. Comparing July 2026 with the pre-crisis baseline, container port

calls surged on the **Indian subcontinent's west coast** (Nhava Sheva up 114 %, plus Hazira, Pipavav, Mundra, and Karachi), at **Salalah** in Oman — outside the strait, the natural regional substitute — and at **Damietta** on Egypt's Mediterranean coast.

The mega-transshipment hubs that would normally absorb a shock — **Colombo** and **Piraeus** — are flat. And Saudi Arabia's Red Sea ports (**Jeddah**, **Dammam**) are *down*, because the Bab-el-Mandeb disruption compounds the Gulf one.



§ 6 Assessment

For container shipping, the Strait of Hormuz is functionally closed and has been since March 2026. There is no recovery trend in the data through late August. The regional container network has partly re-formed around it — Indian west-coast direct calls,

Salalah, and Egyptian Mediterranean transshipment are the load-bearing alternatives — but at a fraction of the lost volume and at longer transit distances.

Two caveats bound this read. First, PortWatch measures vessel movements, not the reasons for them; the March break coincides with the reported *2026 Strait of Hormuz crisis*, but the data attests to the shipping outcome, not its cause. Second, the year-over-year framing answers "still abnormal versus a year ago" — accurate for an event this age, but it would read "recovered" for any disruption older than a year, when both the current and the reference figure are depressed.

Monthly figures — Strait of Hormuz and Jebel Ali, containers				
MONTH	HORMUZ TRANSITS/DAY	HORMUZ CAPACITY/DAY	JEBEL ALI CALLS/DAY	JEBEL ALI IMPORTS/DAY
Sep 25	16.9	438,109	14.3	264,686
Oct 25	17.5	464,005	14.3	295,791
Nov 25	11.6	297,315	13.3	268,172
Dec 25	9.3	295,981	12.9	269,670
Jan 26	10.6	314,648	13.0	313,859
Feb 26	13.2	368,858	13.0	304,601
Mar 26	0.4	9,117	0.6	13,898
Apr 26	0.8	18,917	1.5	32,313
May 26	0.3	3,877	0.7	15,983
Jun 26	1.3	23,774	1.1	19,788
Jul 26	1.0	17,750	2.3	42,047
Aug 26	0.3	3,163	1.6	37,038

§ Method & provenance

Every figure in this brief is reproducible from a local database built by the open-source `bottleneck-logistics` tool and a single generator script. Nothing is hand-transcribed.

DATA SOURCE

IMF PortWatch (portwatch.imf.org) — daily maritime activity estimated from satellite AIS on ~90,000 ships, via the UN Global Platform. Two ArcGIS feature layers: `Daily_Ports_Data` and `Daily_Chokepoints_Data`. Free public use with attribution. Backfill covers 13 Mar 2024 – 23 Aug 2026.

WHAT THE NUMBERS ARE

`n_container` / `portcalls_container` are counts of container-ship transits and port calls. `capacity_container` is the estimated aggregate cargo capacity of those vessels, derived from ship particulars. `import_container` / `export_container` are PortWatch's modelled trade-volume estimates — directional, not measured TEU.

BASELINE

The pre-crisis reference is a fixed window, **November 2025 – February 2026** — the last four stable months before the March break — rather than a rolling baseline, which by mid-2026 would have absorbed the collapse into its own "normal." Percent-of-normal = current value ÷ pre-crisis mean.

"CURRENT" MONTH

July 2026. PortWatch revises its most recent ~2 weeks upward as satellite data lands, so August was still settling at generation time and is shown for context only, marked provisional.

REROUTE ANALYSIS

Candidate substitute ports (Indian west coast, Omani and Red Sea ports, Mediterranean and South Asian transshipment hubs) compared on `portcalls_container`, July 2026 vs the same pre-crisis window. Ranked by percent change; absolute rates shown alongside because small ports swing large percentages off a low base.

REPRODUCE

Run `bottleneck refresh --full` to build the database, then `uv run python scripts/reports/hormuz_container_2026.py`. Full method in `docs/METHODOLOGY.md`.

Limitations

- PortWatch measures throughput (vessels moving), not queue length or berth dwell time. This brief cannot say how long individual ships waited.
- The data attests to the shipping outcome, not the cause. The March 2026 onset coincides with the reported Strait of Hormuz crisis; causation is not established here.

- Trade-volume and capacity fields are model estimates, not manifest data — directionally sound, not exact.
- The year-over-year lens reads "recovered" for any disruption older than ~1 year; this brief uses an explicit fixed pre-crisis window to avoid that.
- The reroute set only includes ports named in the tool's substitution list; an unlisted beneficiary would be missed.

Michael Schertz · built with bottleneck-logistics, an open-source logistics bottleneck & opportunity identifier

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